Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, Section 107) which allows use for commentary, criticism, news reporting, research, teaching or scholarship without requiring permission from the rights holder.

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (315) 859-4071.

Oliver Nelson Jr.

Oliver Nelson Jr. has fashioned a career in music as a flautist, saxophonist and jazz educator. He diligently oversees the music and legacy of his father, Oliver Nelson.

Oliver was interviewed via Zoom on September 10, 2020 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College and I'm very pleased to have Oliver Nelson Jr. with me on a nice afternoon for talking music. And congratulations on your career so far.

ON: Thank you very much.

MR: To make a living in the arts is a challenge but also has some significant rewards I would say.

ON: Why well it's interesting you bring that up, because this is probably the best time of my life that didn't make a lot of money.

MR: Would you extrapolate on that?

ON: Oh yeah, let me give you a little history of me. I got my bachelor's degree in 1977 in music education. Twenty years later I got my master's degree in classical flute performance. I studied with the principal in the Indianapolis Symphony here, and then nineteen years later I decided to go back and get my doctorate at the University of Illinois where I studied with Chip McNeil. So my career has been very varied. In between those times I taught for one year at the Indianapolis Public Schools and I said, well teachers don't make a lot of money, I need to do something else. So I went into the energy field. I didn't even know how to spell energy, Monk. So we were doing energy audits on different facilities around the state of Indiana. I did that for five years for the state. Then I worked for twelve years for the local gas utility, Citizen's Gas here in Indianapolis, and they paid for me to get my master's in classical flute performance at Butler University here, which was really a blessing, it was really cool.

MR: Wow. You and I — not to get off the track but I noticed you and I share a love of Hubert Laws.

ON: Oh yeah. And I actually did my doctoral paper on Hubert. And I've met him several times because he did a lot of work for Dad. He played on the Count Basie "Afrique" album, he played on an album called "The Mayor Speaks" and Dad wrote a suite for strings and jazz orchestra and Hubert played on that. Then he did some television stuff that he would go to L.A. and play. He actually played my first Bundy flute and that was a

playing with the Smithsonian, that was a couple of years ago, and I got a chance to actually present my paper to him and I gave him a copy of it. And it was really neat because he said, "This is one of the best papers on me that I've ever seen."

MR: Oh, that's great.

ON: So, and he's a beautiful player but a beautiful cat.

MR: Um hum. That "Wildflowers" LP that I just think has got it all.

ON: Oh yeah, you know it's interesting that you bring the albums up, because the first album I heard was "Afro Classics" and this is, I think I was 14, 15 years old. My stepmother gave me a flute, I went into a closet and was hyperventilating trying to get a sound out of that thing. And after that I said well — and I looked at his life, because he studied at Juilliard. So I said you really want to play the instrument well. Because once you do that then you can go and learn the language of jazz. So I started to take classical flute lessons and I did that in [inaudible] in Indianapolis I studied with a guy named Albert Saurini who used to be principal at Indianapolis, and then I finally met Karen Moratz who is the present principal now, and I got my master's with her. And then I wanted to get a doctorate but IU didn't have a doctorate in jazz performance. So I went to the University of Illinois and they let me in, so I was playing trumpet parts and stuff with the Latin Jazz band for three years and had to transpose a lot of stuff.

MR: Oh transpose boy.

ON: Oh yeah so I had to do that a while. But it was probably the best experience of my life, Monk. It's interesting. I would sit — we had a thing called a jazz forum at 11:00 on a Friday afternoon. Well I'm the oldest guy in the school, I was probably older than the teachers when I went there. This was about ten years ago. So I'm sitting there and I had to pinch myself. I said I'm sitting here listening and playing music, playing jazz, and guys my age either hate their job and want to get out or try and retire. So it was a great experience. And my family was a little bit different too then because my kids had all grown up, my wife was actually working for the Army in Saudi Arabia. So Illinois was about 125 miles from home so I would get — I got a little flea bag apartment, it really was a flea bag. But I'd drive back home on the weekends to make sure the house was okay. And then I went to fly over to see her several times in the meantime. So my life has been kind of up and, kind of interesting.

MR: Yeah. You've paid some dues. If you went to a cocktail party and someone that you'd never met said, "Well Mr. Nelson, what do you do for a living?" Do you have a short answer?

ON: Oh yeah. I am a full time musician now, and I've never — I've always wanted to do that but now I actually am because I'm teaching adjunct at IU, I'm teaching a jazz for

nothing about it at all. I taught a beginning jazz improv class and we had people in there that couldn't play a blues scale, didn't know what a blues scale was and all that kind of stuff and that was really good. And then I picked up teaching a music industry class. And that class is interesting because what I found out, Monk, is most of the students have no clue of how the music business works. I mean they can play their instruments really well, but I said, "When you get out, how are you going to eat? You know how are you going to pay your rent? How are you going to pay your car note?" And some of them have no clue. And they would say, "Well you know Mr. Nelson, I play in the top orchestra at IU." I say, "Well you know what? You're paying IU to play in that orchestra. You want somebody to pay you to play. So how are you going to make that happen?" And some of them start to get it but then it really makes them kind of think a little bit because schools do really not do a good job of really letting students know what the real world of music is out here. And with Covid it makes it that much different.

MR: I know I have trouble, I've had trouble over the years trying to get my students to realize that they can't just play what they want to if they want to work. You've got to be prepared for any situation, be able to take requests, and so it's tricky. I'm going to guess that you learned what the word "gig" meant early on in life.

ON: Real early on in life. I've got a ton of stories to tell you about gigs and Dad and all that kind of stuff. And I've probably seen more than most because I've seen great players scuffle to play this music. You know but he just sets it down there and you've just got to count this stuff off and go, and it doesn't necessarily go all the time the way you actually want it to go. And then his career was really interesting too because he drove a streetcar in St. Louis for a while, but he always wanted to be into music so eventually he got in the Marines and learned music there and went back to Washington University and studied with a guy named Robert Wykes who was also a flautist, studied with Joseph Mariano at Eastman, but he also got his Ph.D. in composition. So Dad really studied. And that was one of the big differences between him and a lot of jazz guys. He could write anything. [Inaudible] Hollywood really prepared him because he had to write anything at any time for any producer based upon what he was working on at the time.

MR: That came to mind today because I was listening to some of his themes and you went from "The Six Million Dollar Man" with all these sirens and all this, and then to "The Virginian." Like all of a sudden we're going back like a hundred years and it's sort of frontiery, and that's just so admirable.

ON: Well because they had to be prepared to do pretty much anything. It's interesting you mention "The Six Million Dollar Man." From a family royalty standpoint we still get paid for that stuff. Universal owns the rights to the music itself, but we get half of what

Billion Dollar Man and they've been talking about this for twenty years. But they were actually close this time. So I keep in touch with the Universal guy to see if they started and they said no they're still in post-production. And of course then Covid came so I don't know what's going to happen with it. But I was telling some of my students actually yesterday, he did a show called "Longstreet" with a guy names James Franciscus. He was a blind insurance investigator and he was covering this guy that was in jail but he was a trumpet player. So they had this scene where they said, "You know what, Oliver, we really need some music for this trumpet player to be thinking about and playing in this cell." You've got guys in the soundstage, everybody sitting there, he sits down and just starts — and he has to come up with something immediately for the producer to be able to make this scene work. So he really honed his craft with that stuff. When he first went to Hollywood, Monk, it's really interesting, he said he had no clue. Everything, you know you've got to soft whisper a love song and everything's loud. So he had to learn. He had a couple of mentors but one in particular, a guy named Stanley Wilson, he was the head of Universal Television. And Stanley kind of put his arm around my Dad and Stanley kind of took him under his wings and he kind of went from show to show to show. Because Quincy had already been out there. Benny Carter was out there. J.J. moved out there. Benny Golson moved out there, Tom MacIntosh was out there. And a lot of those guys weren't even playing instruments anymore. You know they were composers. So Benny kind of gave everybody the start because he was one of the first African Americans to go out there and compose. And then Quincy followed him. And Quincy got some really great breaks with "The Pawnbroker" and a lot of the movies that he got a chance to do. But Dad wrote the inside music for "Ironside." Because Quincy wrote the theme song for that. He wrote I'll bet you for seven, eight years. I mean it was a long — it might not have been that long but it was a pretty long time. And that's the beauty of residuals. I tell my students that our portfolio now as the music coming [inaudible] has got two components. It's got the jazz component, then it's got the television component. We don't control a lot of the television component, but the television component by far brings in more royalty money than the jazz component any day of the week and on Sunday.

MR: I noticed, I came across a thing I had not been aware of, of a 1975 recording called "Skull Music."

ON: Oh was it "The Skull Sessisons?"

MR: "Skull Sessions." And I noticed it said that some people have been sampling from that. Now does the estate get compensation for that?

ON: They do if we own it. That's the issue. To make sure that we own what they're sampling

what Universal gets. But if it's directly with me, and nobody's contacted me yet and it's interesting how people don't contact you so much. I had this situation happen to me recently, and I want to be — this is a great pianist. He did an album with a lot of Dad's tunes on it. So he contacted me because I work with ejazzline and he wanted to get permission to put his arrangements out. And they paid me a little bit for it so it works out real well. Well I never got clearance from the record company for the tunes originally. And it's amazing, and everything has gone dead since then, just radio silence. You haven't heard anything from anybody. And this guy told me, he said, "Well you know I thought the record company," he told me who the guy was and I thought the record company was supposed to do that, and they were supposed to do that, but my issue is do I start to do copyright infringement because really the only people that really make money in that is the attorneys.

MR: Yeah, you just might give yourself more headaches.

ON: Oh yeah. And actually I did have one I have to share with you. Bela Fleck, the great banjo player, he did an album called "Out Bound" this was several years ago. So my attorney now went to hear Bela play and they did "Hoedown." So Aaron Copland's "Hoedown" is owned by somebody else. So they did [scats] and then in the middle of that hoedown was my Dad's "Hoedown." So I said well this is a copyright infringement. So of course the attorneys start calling and two years later I get a call at midnight from Bela in Germany, he said, "Oliver we really need to kind of work this thing out." So I said, "Well let's do this, Bela," I said, "you pay my attorney's fees" — it was about three grand then so it wasn't a huge amount but it still is money. And I said, "Come to Indianapolis, you record one or two of my Dad's tunes, and you make sure that SONY" because he was with SONY at the time, SONY put something about my Dad on that album. So we finally got it to work. Bela — my attorney now drove down to Louisville, heard the show. They had, the Wooten Brothers were playing with them and stuff, it was great. Bela came home with me. We got home about three o'clock in the morning. My wife was watching TV waiting for me and Bela said, "Well can I sit down and watch this with you guys?" I said, "Sure." So we had a recording session at a place called the Lodge in Indianapolis. About nine o'clock we went to the Lodge — I bought him some breakfast and we went to the Lodge. We recorded some tunes. J.J. Johnson signed — Kevin Johnson actually played on that tune because J.J. is from here and Kevin lives here now, played on that tune. I put Bela on a plane and sent him home.

MR: Oh. Now that was a civilized way to resolve that situation.

ON: Well you're fighting, what good is it going to do? You know what I mean? It just doesn't make any sense at all. And then I've had a couple of — I had to learn the business of

then my brother and I took it over, and I said well let's put an LLC together. So we put an LLC and we structured it a couple of ways. We structured it first of all that the ownership would be 51-49. So I would be the 51 part and he would be the 49 part. He didn't really like that but what that did for me was allow me to be able to do anything with anybody anywhere without having to contact him to get his permission, so I can make deals. And then we split the royalties 50-50. Well I ended up suing one company because they weren't letting me exploit the music the way I wanted to. Of course that took two years and we got about 90 grand out of that one. But my dad learned the hard lesson with the music and I tell my students this all the time. He put out a piano book and it had eleven tunes in there, one of which was "Stolen Moments." Of course musicians never know what their big hit's going to be, and his goal in the early 50s was to be published and to be recorded. I mean that's what you do. So for 700 dollars he basically kind of signed the rights away for that stuff, for 700 bucks, and "Stolen Moments" itself has brought in millions of dollars over that time span. So I had to sue these guys, and they paid us royalties before but you never know who's honest and not. That's the problem with the royalty business. Who's really telling you the truth about this? So I have to live with them, and actually they got bought out, the company, Carlin America got bought out by a company called Round Hill Music which is owned by a bunch of investment bankers. So it's kind of, when Carlin owned them it was really kind of music people. These guys now, you know they're just in it for the money wherever they can get it. But they've been really good and this is the first time that I've worked with a company that I've never talked to anybody physically. Everything is by email. You know what I mean? And the other company I could call if I wanted to talk to the head of accounting, where's my royalty check, I could call the guy and I knew who he was and that kind of stuff. But actually Carlin, they bought Carlin America up with 245 million dollars. Because they have stuff from James Brown, they had stuff from Elvis Presley, they had jazz guys, they had a lot of, you know ownership of tunes.

MR: So let me ask you, back to yourself, musically what's your favorite thing to do?

ON: To play. I like to play more than anything, but my Dad told me something and I never really thought about it, I'm starting to think about it more, he said, "Players come and go, you'll see. You'll see great ones, but if you can write well you can make it." And he found that out. And he was really unique though, Monk, because he could actually play well and he could write well. And see some guys don't have to — Slide Hampton can do the same thing, being able to play and being able to write. So I really need to spend the time. I took some arranging classes in college and I really need to go back, but writing is a craft and it takes as much if not more time to write as it does to practice and play. So to

took forever. You know you're dealing with Sibelius and you're going back and forth and trying to make that stuff work and Hubert is [scats] all this stuff. But I do want to get into writing more. I want to.

MR: Yeah. You know what you said about your father being able to play and write equally well, it, I'm thinking of this record and I've been revisiting this. I still hold on to my favorite LPs. And there's a quote from him in the liner notes. He said, "I get tired of all these guys having all the fun on my dates" so he gave himself some solos.

ON: That's right. And actually his solos with Ron Carter and Steve Coon and those guys, and Grady Tate, they were really great. He played well. But you know what I think helps and I'm learning that Hubert actually told me this, he said, "Dad played like a composer." So he was always thinking. And that's the thing — you know some of us get up and we just start blowing the little licks we've learned, but to really think about what you're doing and Jamey Aebersold pushes that idea of really thinking about what you're going to play and how to structure it. And if you listen to what he did, he was always coming up with a neat idea and he would not let it die before he worked it.

MR: Well go listen — I mean I'm sure you've listened to this a few times. The original recording of "Stolen Moments" his tenor solo on there, he's like, he's composing as he goes, literally.

ON: Oh yeah. He's playing triad pairs.

MR: Yeah. Beautiful. And it's such an interesting contrast. You know you've got Eric Dolphy, who's like —

ON: All over the place.

MR: He's all over the place. And then I mean I just wore it out.

ON: Oh yeah. Interestingly enough, and this is another story, I'm sure Denis told you I'm full of stories here. I got a call from Jamey Aebersold once and Jamey said, "Oliver, did your dad write that solo out before he played it?" And I was highly insulted by that. I said, "Of course he didn't. But he had been thinking about it a lot, he had been thinking about what he wanted to do." He said, "Because that's almost a perfect solo." And it is. It starts simple, he builds those ideas, he goes up and then he brings it back down again. It's just a magnificent study piece in the art of jazz improvisation, to me.

MR: Yes it is. Were you witness to, I guess I'm wondering, because he did so much and you know he'd had these assignments. How did he conceive of new themes? Did you ever witness —

ON: I actually witnessed a couple of times, especially with the television stuff, he was doing an "Ironside" once and there was a race theme in there. And we're sitting in the pool. He kept a little piece of that and he was thinking about [scats] and he said, you know I've got

what he was writing all the time. And he came up with some pretty creative stuff. Plus he was influenced by a lot of the great classical composers. He did a solo on "All the Way" and I was trying to think if it was Moodsville was one of his early Prestige albums. And Bartok's Concerto for Orchestra, I can't remember the movement [scats]. Well he started his cadenza with that. He changed keys, he did all kind of different — and when I first heard it I said, "That's Bartok." But he was very influenced by a lot of those guys. So he would take a lot of time to come up with different stuff. And I think the Hollywood stuff really helped him because he did a movie called "Skullduggery" with a young Burt Reynolds. It was not a great movie. But he had to think of some ideas because this was about the missing link in Australia [scats]. And he wrote a tune called "Afrique" with Count Basie and he actually used that theme and made a tune out of it.

MR: Aha. He must have always been thinking about something musical I would guess.

ON: Always. But you know what? The interesting thing about Dad was kind of like me, if you gave him four weeks for a show, he would never start on it four weeks before. He always did his most creative stuff when he was under the gun. Sometimes he would write 16, 17 hours. I'd try to stay up with him, it's four o'clock in the morning and he's finishing up because he never allowed anybody to orchestrate. He did all that stuff himself. So he would come up with the stuff, write it out, he was very meticulous and very thorough about how he lined his paper, everything. So five o'clock in the morning he's finishing the last score for a scene. We'd drive to Universal Studios, because this was before emails and sending files, drop it off, go back home, take a shower. The copyists have got it by six, and at eight o'clock the musicians are sitting on the soundstage and he's got to conduct all day.

MR: Oh my Lord.

ON: Oh, so it was a really pretty tough schedule. And he learned that you're no better than your producer. If your producer does not like you you're done.

MR: Now did he write — on the score pad did he use a pencil?

ON: Yeah.

MR: Okay.

ON: These little Scripto mechanical pencils that you would — he had a million of them and he'd use those all the time. And it's funny I still have some of the old manuscript paper. You can't even find the stuff anymore.

MR: Yes.

ON: Now you've got eight by ten sheets with a million ledger lines on there and you're trying to read the score. 'Cause see back in those days you had big scores so you could actually see that stuff and read it.

ON: Nobody uses that stuff anymore.

MR: Yes. Oh gee. And I'd just like to think, you know nowadays everyone's at a computer but the physical act of putting a note on the paper, it's sort of like you're really invested in it. You know?

ON: Oh yeah. And I learned that lesson the hard way, up at two, three in the morning copying drum parts by hand in an arranging class. I said, "This stuff is crazy." But the interesting thing is he knew the transpositions, he had a little cheat sheet, Monk, that he used for the alto clef for the viola. He'd pull that out, but he knew all the transpositions and the guys today, if they write a score it's in concert. And somebody's got to transpose it. He never — everything was written out exactly the way it was supposed to be.

MR: Wow. I bet the copyists liked your father.

ON: Oh yeah. And he was very neat. It's interesting, I don't know if you read, there was an article that Creed Taylor did on Dad and he was talking about Impulse when he first started out. Because "Blues and the Abstract Truth" was one of the original eight albums that they did. Trane had one, J.J. had one, and actually there's an anniversary set that you can buy with the eight albums on there. And Creed was saying that there was a difference between him and Gil Evans. Dad was very meticulous, very neat and Gil was all over the place.

MR: What about song titles? Did he ever have music that he had written, original music, that he had trouble thinking what do I call this?

ON: Well it's interesting, he would think of those when they had to go on a record. But I've got a ton of scores of N-201s and 302s and that kind of, and I have to sit down and figure out a lot of times what they were. And some of this stuff has never been done. And I've got boxes and boxes of music and I've had one of my students kind of help me catalogue stuff but then Covid came around so she can't even come to the house anymore. But most of the stuff he had a good name for. That book of eleven songs, he had one called "One for Brucie." That was my nickname. B-R-U-C-I-E. My mother got this name from a kid on TV that she saw. So the name just kind of stuck with me in my family, but nobody else knows me by that but family members. "Teenie's Blues" and "Miss Fine," they were both written for his sister, Leontine LaCoste. She was a pianist and she did the piano bar thing in St. Louis, and they loved each other immensely but would fight like cats and dogs. But both of those — because my aunt was a very elegant person. So that's why he called her "Miss Fine." He wrote that big band arrangement of "Miss Fine" for her, and then "Teenie's Blues" came off the "Blues and the Abstract Truth" album too.

MR: In our collection at the college I have a score your dad did for Joe Williams, and so nothing seemed to faze him. I wonder, did he seem compelled to take every offer given to

ON: I think in Hollywood he was afraid not to take offers. Because my stepmother would always say, you know, we've got enough money, you don't have to work anymore. But I think his point was out of sight, out of mind. So you kind of had to keep the system rolling there as far as doing stuff, and that didn't help him. Plus he wouldn't go to the doctor. All the reports you probably read say he died of a heart attack but he didn't die of a heart attack at all. He died from pancreatitis and metamorphosis of the liver, which are both alcohol related. And I tell my students this all the time, I say, you know what? You can't do that because your problems don't go away the next day, they're still there, and a lot of times they're worse than that. But you know you try to drown your personal sorrows and all that stuff with alcohol and it just doesn't do any good. And I think if he had taken better care of himself physically that way he would have been okay. I think he might have been a little afraid to go to the doctor, personally. This is just my personal opinion.

MR: Uh huh. Did he and your mother or your stepmother encourage you — well how did they feel about you pursuing music as a career?

ON: Well my mother was fine with it. Actually when I was going to college Dad wanted me to go study with David Baker at IU, but my mother, because she is a Seventh Day Adventist, very church related, "No, send him to this church school." Well he did it the first year, then the second year, by the fourth year he had kind of given up. So I kind of learned stuff on my own. I had a really good ear but actually this experience that I had at Illinois I learned more about music there than I ever learned in my life. And I wish I could have started learning that earlier, just the intricacies of improvisation, what you have to do, all the transcriptions we have to do in order to sound good, all that kind of stuff. And a lot of guys have really good ears, but everybody can't be an intricate improviser. Some people have to work at it. You have to really study the guys, and then you'll get your own sound eventually, but you sound like them sometimes before you get your own sound. So I'm learning that on the other end. But you know that's okay. Life is going pretty well. Like I said I love teaching, even though I'm doing Zoom teaching. I usually buy bagels for my students every semester, I can't buy bagels for them this time.

MR: Yeah, you just have to eat it in front of them and, "Boy, I wish you could share in this."

ON: Oh yeah. But encouraging young people to me is a privilege. Because a lot of these kids have no clue, like I said before. And I told them, I said my class is important but I'm more interested in your character and your integrity and your development as a person. If you do that that's all I care about. In my jazz for listening class I said my goal for you is this: if you're at a restaurant with your parents, and you hear "Take the A Train" and somebody says, "Why that's Duke Ellington's 'Take the A Train.'" You say, "No that's

an airport and you hear, "Oh boy that sounds like Professor Nelson's Dad's 'Stolen Moments." That's what I'm looking for for those kids, to introduce them to the music and to keep that little flame going.

MR: I'll drink to that. But not too much.

ON: That's right. Not too much. You've got to be careful with it.

MR: Do you have your own, I mean you pretty much just said it, do you have your own opinion on the jazz education as a whole in the United States? It's certainly a big business and there's a built-in issue with all these graduates, what are they going to do in a business that isn't as robust as the education.

ON: I think you said it best when you said when we were talking before, you said, this: you've got to be versatile. See the days for me, if I could go out and play post-bop like Joe Henderson and those guys, that's the music that I really love. You're not going to eat on that. You've got to find a way to eat, man. So if Kanye's got something and he needs a saxophone player to come in to play something, you've got to be able to play with him. Or if the symphony is doing a Ravel piece and they need a saxophone player you need to be able to do that. Or if there's a wedding coming up and you know what, I really don't like to play weddings but it pays a couple of thousand dollars, you'd be a fool —

MR: "I'll be there."

ON: That's right. So they've got to look — and they also need to look at skills like writing. You need to — I think the guys that are successful can write a little bit, they play, they're versatile, and a lot of the different things they can do — because the purists are the guys that have the big names and big jobs is less than one tenth of one percent. You know Wynton and those guys, they're a very tiny part — of course everybody wants to be like that, but my friend Kevin said his dad J.J. says, he said, "The stars only fall on a few." And he's right. So what can I do to make a living doing what I love to do every day. And that's kind of what I challenge them with.

MR: Well said. Was it a big decision, are you aware of, when your family relocated? Now you were in New York for a while is that right?

ON: Yeah, Dad was in New York for a while, but he always wanted to be a composer in Hollywood. That was something that he always wanted to do. The Marconis and the Newman Brothers and all those guys, Hollywood was where he really wanted to go. So he got an agent and he lived in the Beverly — oh what's it — the Beverly Hawaiian Hotel. I can't remember the name of it, it's been so long ago. He bought a Yamaha spinet piano there, got an agent, started putting a portfolio together, and the first thing that he wrote for was called "I Love a Mystery." And I remember [scats] I can remember some of the songs, and then they'd have love scenes in there. And so he had to shop this stuff

in the door. But I always say that Dad was really good but he was very fortunate to be in the right place at the right time. Because in the 60s man, they were looking for African-American composers. They was looking for guys that could write. You know that was back in the black —

MR: Why? Can you tell me why?

ON: Because there is — I think part of it was because of the race issues that was going on in the middle 60s. You know black equality, all that kind of stuff, and Hollywood said I think we could make some money on some of this stuff. So they had the "Shaft" movies come out, and a lot of that stuff came out, and so they was looking for African-Americans to be able to write for that stuff. So he happened to be lucky, but also he was good enough that he could transcend anything. So if they needed a string quartet for a scene in the morning he could write a string quartet. If they needed a big band in the afternoon he could write for a big band. You know you talk about westerns, I've never known how those little pianos at the bars, "tack" pianos. They put tacks on the hammers. And I'd never been exposed to that. Also Dad was the guy that introduced synthesizers to Universal Studios. He was writing for it and they didn't even have one. Benny Golson had a portable and they had to rent Benny Golson's portable Moog and bring in [inaudible] and stuff. And you listen to the "Six Million Dollar Man," all those sounds he actually created those at home himself.

MR: No kidding. Turning the dials and all that stuff.

ON: Oh yeah. [scats]

MR: I'll be darned.

ON: Yeah he created it. And of course Universal owns those, so they get royalties from that kind of stuff too. But he had a Moog synthesizer and he actually went to New York and met Robert Moog himself to learn. And back in those days everything was monophonic. So you've got phase shifters and you've got sine and sawtooth waves and you've got — so he was making those telephone patch chords. And he'd make them himself so he could plug one into the other. He bought an Ampex 8-track tape recorder in the 60s. That thing was $20,000, I'll never forget.

MR: Oh my God.

ON: And it had inch-thick tape on there, and it had sel-sync, so you could record over yourself and it would synchronize with everything else. So he was doing all that kind of stuff.

MR: Where did he learn his craft as far as just writing a big band arrangement? Was it just listening?

ON: Well he actually said it was a guy named John Cotter who was — he was the musical director for Della Reese. And he learned a lot of the big band stuff there. And then he

Louis-Kansas City area. There were several funeral directors, and I can't remember some of the names of some of these guys, but they had big bands and Dad played there. So he learned how to write there. But in order to be able to write Stravinsky, Schoenberg, that kind of stuff, he went to school. And that's when he went to study at Washington University.

MR: Okay. I just wanted to tell you that I don't know if you know that your father made the 1960 edition of Leonard Feather's book.

ON: Oh yeah. Leonard Feather loved my dad, man.

MR: It mentions that he was a cab driver and studied taxidermy perhaps?

ON: Yup. He studied taxidermy for a while and thought about going into the undertaking business. And actually he wanted to get his pilot's license. He never did that, but he had a lot of interests. But one of the big things he did for leisure was model railroading. He would build elaborate train layouts. He actually built one for me personally and I didn't take care of it very well, but he had the mountains and all that stuff, went to Japan and bought brass engines and brought them back, and he was really — because his father was a Pullman porter on the railroad. So trains had always been a part of his life and he loved model railroads. So he was a tinkerer. He could take your timing belt out of your car and fix that if it needed to be done, just a really, really interesting guy.

MR: What kind of things — I'm going to ask this of him and then I'm going to ask it of you so you have a chance to think — what kind of thing would make your father angry?

ON: Probably lack of preparation for musicians that he had to work with. He would get really pretty upset about that. It's funny you mentioned "Sound Pieces." Well you know the piece itself was pretty difficult with the bass clar — [scats]. Well they couldn't play it. When they first were recording they couldn't play the piece. He sent them home. And they came back and they had to play it the next day. So that stuff, and then the racial situation in the country really got him upset. There's a place in St. Louis that, you know, you wanted to get a hamburger but black people had to go around the back. And he really couldn't stand that kind of thing. That's why the album he did, "Black, Brown and Beautiful" was so significant. Because he'd learned a couple of things. One thing he learned was that was at a time when you know Africa was the motherland for us African-Americans here in the United States. But the Africans didn't claim us. We were Americans. And he learned that pretty quickly. He said you know we put stock in this country and we have to be proud of the stock that we have put in this country. And then he did a piece called "Self Help is Needed" actually the IU band is going to play that, I just gave some music to the IU guys a couple of days ago. And I wanted them to play it, especially during these racial times. Because we cannot wait, as African-Americans, for

should be peaceful, I believe it should be organized, but you can't wait for others. You have to go on. And he was really into that kind of thing a whole lot.

MR: That's wonderful to hear. And how about yourself? What gets under your collar?

ON: Not much. I'm pretty, I'm challenged right now because I have an 87-year-old mother who lives with me and she's got dementia. So sometimes, we were up there today and she has not been able to go to church. She's a big churchgoer. She said, "We're going to church today?" I says, "No, Mom." And of course she will ask you that fifty times. So having patience to deal with that is tough. And in her situation she can still dress herself. She can still take baths, she can still do stuff, but it's just challenging to go through that a lot. And it's not angry necessarily but this is a lady that graduated from high school when she was 15, graduated from college when she was 19, has two master's degrees, one in Spanish and one in counseling. But dementia doesn't care.

MR: Didn't your mother get multiple degrees also?

ON: Yeah this is — my stepmother did, but my mother, my physical mother did. So that's who I'm talking about.

MR: Yes.

ON: So she's staying with me now and my dad taught me something because he made sure that he was going to take care of his family. He built a house in [inaudible] Missouri for his mom and dad, and he made sure that he, as his success rose that he made sure he took care of them. We were really a pretty close family. So that kind of challenges me a lot. The racial situation challenges me. I have a son who is an attorney and actually this is interesting — when George Floyd was killed one of his clients saw the police and stuff deal with George Floyd before he was murdered. And my son had an interview with Chris Cuomo on CNN. And he was very eloquent and my dad would have been very proud of him to do that kind of stuff. But living as an African-American even at 65 years old, I'm suspect to get stopped at any time.

MR: Yes.

ON: I mean, and that is awful.

MR: We are in the midst of a historically turbulent year in so many ways. Are you a spiritual man?

ON: Yes.

MR: Do you have any thoughts about why all this is occurring now?

ON: I think, and I'm just going to go from my Bible reading and that kind of stuff that I do a lot. The Bible talks about these kinds of things happening. But I've never seen it to this degree before in my life. And I've talked to a lot of people that are a lot older than me and they say they've never seen anything. Because the Bible talks about pestilence, it

having all this stuff right while we speak. So from a spiritual standpoint, and I'm a believer in eternity and that kind of stuff. So it's just kind of pointing to what is going to happen in the future. And that's just my personal opinion. I talk to my students sometimes, of course you don't want to talk religion too much at school. I kind of keep away from that. But basically they have no use for it at all. A lot of them don't. Because they've seen the hypocrisy from parents and, you know from other people of if you're a believer in Christ what Christ would do versus what you see. And one thing that really does get me angry is the Evangelical right and the embracement of a guy that has no moral background too much at all. And I'm just speaking — this is just me talking. And they are, it's like the Pharisees of old, they killed Jesus and some people were looking the other way. As long as you can get your agenda taken care of, we don't care. And that (A) drives me nuts.

MR: It drives me nuts too. And I guess sometimes people say well it's all about as long as they get the conservative judges they want or something, but that seems like a poor excuse to me.

ON: It's a real poor excuse and young people see that phoniness and they don't want to have any part of it. And that's the thing, it really bothers me. If something gets me angry, that gets me angry more than anything else. And now we don't know how the election is going to turn out. I'm going to go vote early, and I'm going to do my little two cents, because that's all you can do. But you know what I try to do my classes and we talk about it and I say, "You guys go out and vote." See the last time the young people didn't vote. And they've got to go out and vote. You're seeing all this unrest, but the beautiful thing, especially about the racial unrest, is the joining of African-Americans and white Americans, and all nat— it's a beautiful sight. When Dr. King did his speech in sixty— you didn't see that. But today, I mean it's just a beautiful rainbow of people out there that are all stripes, and to me that what this country is all about.

MR: That's hopeful.

ON: Yes.

MR: Thank you for saying that. I wanted to read a couple more quotes. First of all, name this tune. You ready?

ON: Okay.

MR: You'll have to forgive my vocalizing.

ON: That's all right.

MR: [Scats].

ON: [Scats]. From "The Kennedy Dream."

MR: I love it. And Nat Hentoff, who wrote more than one set of liner notes for your father

implications to this music," followed by your father saying, "It could be for trombone and snare drum." So my question is, and it's sort of a broad question—

ON: And I answered that wrong by the way but that's okay.

MR: Yes. You knew it was "Sound Pieces," yes.

ON: Yeah.

MR: As a matter of fact I have —

ON: Actually it was written for French horn if you listen to it, and he had French horns playing really high on that thing. The Smithsonian did it and some of those guys were scuffling.

MR: You know I'm sort of glad — not glad — I find that interesting also, the fact that you said in the original session that cats couldn't cut it. Because we tend to think that at that level they're infallible. They can just play — people like to say first time perfect. Right? Not necessarily so.

ON: No. And if the music is tough you've got to woodshed that stuff just like anybody else does.

MR: Okay. Now I think I lost my question. Actually this is something I think about a lot. What does music mean? And when he called it "Sound Pieces" he could have called it something descriptive, he could have dedicated it to something. But he called it "Sound Pieces," just like Samuel Barber called that beautiful piece "Adagio for Strings."

ON: The strings. Yeah.

MR: So I'm struggling to ask my question, but does music have to have a deeper meaning other than it's just beautiful music?

ON: I think it does not. I think it can just be beautiful. If you read the liner notes on that album you see when he said, "Why did you name that 'Sound—.'" He said, "It's a piece that sounds." That's what Dad quoted, and I think that's what he was thinking just beautiful sound and stuff. We would — this is really interesting — but we would get together sometimes and he and I would cry just about beautiful sounds that we would hear and beautiful pieces that we would hear, and that kind of stuff. So beauty to him musically was a big deal. Now some things had special meaning, if you look at "The Kennedy Dream." And I was thinking about "The Kennedy Dream." All those pieces have a certain meaning. I mean they were all written for a certain thing. But that "Sound Pieces" was just a creative idea and that's why I think he loved Bob Thiele so much. Because Bob would give him creative license to do pretty much anything he wanted. And Dad was lucky that he could get people to play instrumentations. "Flute Salad." You've got four alto flutes. I mean especially back then. Now you can find them today but back then who's got four alto flutes? And then he got a big band with French horns. You hire more

do that he would give him license to be able to write pretty much whatever he wants to, which is a really neat thing.

MR: I get such a charge out of still reading the personnel on music that came out of Los Angeles at that time. And you just — I mean I write arrangements too and I sometimes think oh my God if I could have that assemblage of people and have them play a chart of mine, that would be like so incredible.

ON: Oh yeah. And this was normal stuff for him. I mean Buddy Collette, Bud Shank, Tom Scott, all those guys, Bobby Bryant on trumpet. I mean Garnett Brown on trombone, Shelly Manne played with them all the time. Ray Brown played with him a whole bunch of the time. So that was just kind of his normal set of people to play his music.

MR: Would he come home and talk about his day?

ON: Come home exhausted sometimes, especially with the television stuff.

MR: Yes.

ON: He said, "Man I don't want to hear another note for a long time." That would last about two days and then he's — "Well I'm ready to get back." And everybody needs to get away from that stuff. Because it's a factory. I mean it literally is a factory. You kind of put this stuff out and you've got to do it within a certain timeframe and you've got to make sure it's right. And the technology was so different, Monk, then than it is now. I'm going to see if I can point something to you. I'm going to turn the screen around. If you look, you see that big brown clock up there?

MR: Go a little higher.

ON: Okay. There it is.

MR: Yeah. A little higher.

ON: Okay.

MR: Okay, got it.

ON: That clock was the clock that he used to write music for Universal, for television. Because what they would do back then was they would give a cue sheet out and the cue sheet was all timed to a tenth of a second. So the Six Million Dollar Man throws this ball at 2 minutes 22 seconds, and the ball goes slow. And he'd have to use that clock to time everything to a tenth of a second. When you went to the soundstage they had a big clock like that too. And what they would do is the music editors would have to use a thing called a streamer. So they'd scratch the film, because you had this big, big movie screen there and that would tell him when the music started and it would tell him when the music had to stop. So he had to use that clock to be able to write that stuff.

MR: Wow. And I bet you wouldn't want to be the person in the band who made a real clunker.

ON: Oh no, no, no, no, no. You really wouldn't. But you know what he tried to conduct, and

was I talking to — oh it was Sheridon Stokes is a flute player. And he did some stuff in California with Dad and one time he said well they needed somebody to play tympani. Well Dad went back and played the tympani. So you do whatever it takes to make the deal work. I mean there was a lot of different interesting people. Carol Kaye, a member of the Rat Pack, Carol Kaye that did all the stuff — well he'd write parts out for Fender bass. He called her "Fender Bass" and he'd have parts for her to play the Fender bass on. But it was an interesting time because Ray Brown had a bass in every studio. The horn players, Bud Shank and those guys, they had a cartage service and they would actually have this service come and pick their instruments up and take it to the next studio. So they didn't even lug horns anymore. And I mean they were making pretty — I mean you make 250, 300 bucks for four hours, then you go to another studio and you do that. And I always tell my students, we talk about how much guys for television make today. Dad was making about 3000 dollars a show. And it was a 26-week season back then so it was a lot longer than it is today.

MR: Three thousand a show, what is that, how is that divided up into services?

ON: So you'd come and you'd write the music and you'd conduct the music and they'd have a check drawn for three grand.

MR: I see.

ON: And so you'd have 26 of those three grands going. And then they'd have him do other projects. So then he had the jazz stuff he was still doing, plus he was doing — he was actually making 250 to 300 thousand dollars a year back in the 70s. So he was doing real well —

MR: Go ahead.

ON: No he was doing real well and he needed to turn some stuff down but he didn't. He just wanted to keep that whole ship running because you never know when it's going to dry out.

MR: Yeah. Did he ever recycle themes? Like write something for a show and it didn't really fit. Two years later say I got something for this, I already have it.

ON: Oh yeah. I mean composers love the sound of their own selves. And actually he used some of those things for different, like I said on the "Afrique" album if you listen to "Afrique" that was from television.

MR: I see.

ON: And so he would, and all those guys do that kind of stuff. So he would recycle some stuff. But then he was always trying to find different stuff too. He studied with a guy named George Tremblay. And George Tremblay was working with Quincy and a lot of guys out there using twelve tone techniques. So he really got into serial composition and

got into — if you look at his *Patterns for Improvisation* there's a twelve tone row that he's got. And I can't remember what exercise it is now but I was just playing it the other day. So he really wanted to get into that. You know I'm going to digress one second. You said something that really would get him angry? One thing that would get him angry was being recognized not just as a jazz musician. And that would bother him. That bothered David Baker too. Because I mean David was a tremendous writer. He could write anything. But you know they always wanted to pigeon hole the African-Americans into this kind of hole and then they would only call them like if it was a symphony or something they would only call them during Black History Week. And that would get him upset because he probably would have won a Pulitzer Prize but they weren't giving those out to African-Americans back in those days.

MR: That's right. Even Ellington.

ON: That would get him upset.

MR: I see. What's in the near — I have to stop this question. I was going to say what's in the near future, but none of us know.

ON: We don't know. I'm supposed to —

MR: We're all in sort of this Zoom world and some of us are making it through better than others I guess.

ON: Well it's interesting, a guy named Brent Wallarab, he's one that teaches at IU, he teaches arranging and composition and stuff. He's doing this concert of my dad's music and asked me to play on it. And I wanted some of my jazz for listening students to come. Well I talked to the head of the department and he said well I have to check and see. Because they might not let you. And these guys were having rehearsals, and everybody is so separated. So he's trying to put them in clusters kind of close together so you can get a blend. Because you can't get a blend anymore. The orchestra down there, all those guys are doing Zoom. The jazz guys with the big bands are able to have rehearsals but the whole room is all spread out.

MR: You know I have a nine member saxophone ensemble and they constantly are slowing down. And I'm going what's the problem. Well there's 60 feet from one end to the other.

ON: So how do you hear? You can't hear. I was looking at the Green Mill in Chicago, great jazz club, they opened back up and they said you know what? No horn players and no vocalists.

MR: Really?

ON: Yup?

MR: Oh because of the aerosol.

ON: Well I thought it was the Green Mill because the Green Mill did the same thing too. But no vocalists and no horn players. So how are you going to run a club like that? But you know what you're blessed, Monk. I fell I'm blessed too, to be able to have a teaching gig.

MR: Yes.

ON: I mean that brings still money into your coffers and that's a good thing to have and today, like you said, you've got tons of guys — I remember ten years ago they would not allow a doctor of jazz studies. Now there's a ton of them. And everybody's looking for work.

MR: Right. When's that guy going to retire?

ON: That's right. Don't do it anytime — you know my philosophy of retiring is I probably never will. As long as I can still play and do that kind of stuff, and for me music is to touch the lives positively of others. Clark Terry said something once I'll never forget. He said you know what I want people to feel better when they leave than when they come in.

MR: All right. Well that sounds like a good note to wrap up with. And I've so much enjoyed this conversation. I had a feeling I would.

ON: But did you get enough information?

MR: I did. We might have to do part two down the road.

ON: That's fine, and I've got more stories for you if you need — I just really appreciate you thinking of me, and Denis thinking of me. So it's always an honor to talk about my — this helps keep his legacy alive. And that's the thing that's very — tell me about your school and tell me about your archives if you can.

MR: Well Hamilton College is a very old college. It goes back to the early 1800s. It's a liberal arts school. It's small. It's a gorgeous place, a nice place to work.

ON: How many music students do they have?

MR: We don't have many music majors. We have a nice crop of talented students, we have about six professors. This project I do came about because a Hamilton grad of the class of 1944 was a very enthusiastic supporter of swing music and, you know, jazz of the 30s through the 50s. And he decided that many of his musical heroes were passing away without having their stories told. So I lucked into the job of starting to do videotaped interviews and we decided together, you know we focused on people with the Basie orchestra first. Because Joe Williams the singer helped us get started.

ON: Oh cool.

MR: Yeah. So we've been at it since 1995 and we've done 400 plus video interviews. It's been a dream gig for me I'll tell you that.

ON: Oh you can't beat that man. You can't beat getting paid for doing this.

MR: Wait a minute you mean I could get paid for this?

ON: So what do you teach?

MR: I teach saxophone lessons and an ensemble. And the archive job is a half-time job at the college so I'm there like 65%.

ON: Well that's great.

MR: Yeah. And it gives me time to play gigs, not right now.

ON: When is the last gig you played? Do you remember?

MR: The last gig I played — I've played about four times since the end of February. And you know I used to play four times a week.

ON: Oh yeah. And it's awful. I was thinking about some of the guys that came to Jamey's camp. A lot of those guys had contracts to do shows. Broadway shows. And they're not doing anything. I was talking to a friend of mine the other day, the Indianapolis Symphony cancelled all the health insurance for all the orchestra members. So it's just hard times man. I've never seen anything like this ever.

MR: This is definitely the blues.

ON: Oh yeah. Oh I did — a friend of mine we've been doing a string of shows outside in her backyard so I went down to play that. And then there was a guy that wants me to come up and do a jazz clinic in Minnesota, but you know you don't even know if you're going to have this stuff. You know JEN is supposed to be in Louisville. I don't even know if they're going to have JEN. So everything is kind of up in the air.

MR: Definitely. Well let's hope for the best and be positive, as you have said a number of times today.

ON: Oh yeah. And this is really giving me a chance to kind of get my skill — it gives you a chance to kind of do some stuff that you wouldn't necessarily have time to do because you were too busy doing other things.

MR: Yes.

ON: So I'm trying to work on my piano chops and I've been going through Mark Levine's *Jazz Theory* book for this class that I've been teaching, and trying to boost myself up.

MR: Yeah. All right. Well thank you very much for your time today.

ON: Thank you very much for asking me, and just give me a call. By the way I sent that information, I sent it to you.

MR: I did get it, yup, I did get it.

ON: Okay. But if you want to do something else just let me know.

MR: Okay.

ON: It's been a pleasure. Thank you so much, man.

MR: See you in the flip side.

ON: Yes sir. Bye-bye.

MR: Bye-bye.